

Series Title: The Simple Things

Dates: January 26 - February 16, 2025

Vision For The Event

We have three rules in our house:

- Show Kindness
- Offer Grace
- Practice Mercy

We are not always good at following them, but they shape how we want to live our lives. These rules govern how Brianna and I try to model a Christian witness for our children because they are a central part of how Jesus lived and taught us to live.

Like much of Jesus' actions and teachings, these rules seem simple. "It should be simple just to be kind. However, as we all know, something might seem simple, but it can also be the hardest thing we've ever done."

Through this series, we'll explore these three simple but profound rules by looking at Scripture and the life of Jesus. Though seemingly simple, we'll discover how kindness, grace, and mercy are transformative actions that require our full commitment and effort.

The success of this series will be evaluated by:

- The congregation's ability to understand and apply kindness, grace, and mercy in their daily lives.
- How well the sermons connect these virtues to the life and teachings of Jesus.
- Engagement in group discussions or personal reflection on these themes.

Sermon Schedule

Sunday	Sermon Title	Scripture	Supplemental Scriptures
1/26	Simple Doesn't Mean Easy	Philippians 2:1-5	1 Peter 1:14-16
2/2	Show Kindness	Ruth 1:6-22	Ephesians 4:31-32
2/9	Offer Grace	John 8:1-11	Ephesians 2:8-9, Romans 3:23-24
2/16	Practice Mercy	Matthew 18:21-35	Lamentations 3:22-23

Summaries of each sermon were compiled by Chat GPT.

Week 1 | Simple Doesn't Mean Easy - Philippians 2:1-5

At first glance, virtues like kindness, grace, and mercy seem simple, almost second nature to a person of faith. But simple doesn't mean easy. Paul's letter to the Philippians challenges us to adopt the mindset of Christ, one marked by humility and selflessness. Imagine a team of rowers, each person pulling their oar in perfect unison—not for personal glory, but for the shared goal. The Christian life is similar; living out simple virtues requires aligning our hearts with Christ's, even when it feels counterintuitive or costly.

Christ's example of humility reminds us that these virtues demand intentional effort and sometimes sacrificial love. It's easy to be kind when others are kind to us, but what about when we're wronged? It's easy to show mercy when the stakes are low, but what about when it's costly? Like training for a marathon, these "simple" acts require practice and perseverance. Through Paul's words, we're reminded that though the path of humility may be difficult, it leads to true unity and joy in Christ.

Week 2 | Show Kindness - Ruth 1:6-22

Kindness often begins with a decision to remain present, even when it's easier to walk away. Ruth's journey of kindness begins not in the field with Boaz, but on the road to Bethlehem, where she makes the astonishing choice to stay with Naomi. Ruth's words, "Where you go, I will go; where you lodge, I will lodge; your people shall be my people, and your God my God," are a profound act of kindness rooted in steadfast loyalty and sacrificial love. Imagine standing at a crossroads, one path leading to safety and familiarity, the other to uncertainty and hardship. Ruth chose the latter, embodying the essence of covenantal kindness.

This week, we'll reflect on how kindness sometimes requires us to step into someone else's suffering. Ruth's choice to stay with Naomi is not just an act of companionship—it is a commitment to share in her burdens, a reflection of God's faithfulness. In our relationships,

kindness often involves more than a kind word or gesture; it demands our presence, our time, and our willingness to shoulder the weight of another's pain. Ruth's story challenges us to consider: How can we, like Ruth, model God's unyielding kindness in the lives of those around us? Through her example, we see that kindness has the power to transform not just relationships, but entire destinies.

Week 3 | Offer Grace - John 8:1-11

In a moment of public shame, the woman caught in adultery is dragged before Jesus, her accusers demanding judgment. Jesus' response—stooping to write in the dust—invites reflection. Instead of aligning himself with the crowd's thirst for retribution, Jesus offers grace, saying, "Let anyone among you who is without sin be the first to throw a stone." His words diffuse the anger, leaving room for restoration instead of condemnation.

This week, we'll explore how offering grace requires courage and a deep understanding of our own need for it. Grace is not condoning sin; it is offering a chance for repentance and transformation. Like Jesus, we're called to see beyond a person's actions and recognize their inherent worth as a child of God. Extending grace, especially when judgment feels justified, mirrors God's grace toward us. It's a radical act of love that invites others—and us—into a deeper experience of God's mercy.

Week 4 | Practice Mercy - Matthew 18:21-35

Jesus' parable of the unmerciful servant is a stark reminder of how much mercy we've received and how much we're called to extend. The servant, forgiven an unpayable debt, refuses to forgive a much smaller one owed to him. This disconnect reveals how easily we can forget the magnitude of God's mercy in our lives. Imagine a person drowning in an ocean being rescued, only to later deny a cup of water to someone thirsty.

Practicing mercy means recognizing that we are all recipients of God's infinite mercy and are called to pass it on. Forgiveness can be one of the hardest things to offer, especially when the wounds are deep. Yet Jesus makes it clear that mercy is not optional in God's kingdom—it is the very currency of grace. When we practice mercy, we reflect the heart of God and foster reconciliation and healing in our relationships, making visible the kingdom of heaven on earth.